understanding of its interests will strengthen India. We must continue to compete effectively, especially in our immediate periphery.

Establishing a stable balance between India and China after 2020 is not easy. If that has to emerge, it can only become sustainable on the basis of three mutuals. The international situation could even contribute to that process, as India strives to find an optimal positioning in the East–West and North–South divides. But there has to be an acceptance of multipolarity in Asia. The last few years have been a period of serious challenge, both for the relationship and for the prospects of the continent. The continuation of tensions will have its consequences. New normals of posture will inevitably lead to new normals of strategy. Whether a long-term view of their ties will prevail is the big question.

The India–China relationship is now truly at a crossroads. The national will, policy confidence, global relationships and growing capabilities of India are on display. Choices that are made will have profound repercussions, not just for the two nations but for the entire world. Respecting the three mutuals and applying the resulting propositions to the growth of their ties may help both nations to make the right decisions. That is best done when the relationship is approached with clinical analysis, global strategy and delivery on the ground. It is only when our approach to China is steeped in realism that we will strengthen our image before the world as Bharat.